



The DNA of Great Classic Quest Design

Lessons from Classic World of Warcraft

A framework for understanding why some quests become so memorable, and how those principles can inform new experiences.

Memorable Quests leverage curiosity, exploration, pacing, worldbuilding, empathy, and shared adventure to create *meaningful player journeys*

Curiosity

A question the player wants answered

Exploration

The journey becomes part of the reward

Pacing

Information and emotion revealed over time

Worldbuilding

The world becomes the main character, and quests paint the picture

Empathy

Players become invested in people and places

Shared Adventure

Create opportunity for players to meet, cooperate, and share stories together

Crafting Experiences That Have Impact

These quests serve as case studies for understanding the design principles behind memorable player experiences

Design Principles of Classic Questing

Quest Name	What it Teaches
Legend of Stalvan	Curiosity
The Missing Diplomat	Exploration
Tirion Fordring - Redemption	Pacing
Defias Brotherhood	Worldbuilding
Mankrik's Wife	Empathy
Mor'Ladim	Shared Adventure

Curiosity

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Quests teach players about the world they inhabit

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Design Principle 1: Curiosity

Curiosity creates intrinsic motivation by giving players a reason to care about what happens next

Start with a question

- Give players something they may genuinely want answered

Create an information gap

- Reveal enough to spark curiosity, but not enough to satisfy it

Sustain curiosity with new discoveries

- Each reveal should naturally pull the player forward

Let players uncover the truth

- Discovery is more rewarding than exposition

Quest Examples that demonstrate strong Curiosity

Mankrik's Wife

Defias Brotherhood

Tirion - Redemption

**Windsor
Onyxia Attunement**

**Missing Diplomat
Long-form Mystery**

**Linken's
Adventure**

Case Study: *The Legend of Stalvan*

A mystery quest chain that keeps the player unraveling the story as they complete each step

How *The Legend of Stalvan* excels with Curiosity

Starts with a question

Madame Eva asks the player to speak with Clerk Daltry regarding a name: **Stalvan Mistmantle**. The player immediately wonders: *Who is Stalvan and why is this name important?*

Create an information gap

Daltry knows pieces of the story but not the whole truth. The player learns something happened, but not what happened.

Turn locations into discoveries

The investigation uncovers letters, records, and witnesses. Each clue answers one question while raising another.

Let players uncover the truth

Instead of narrating the story directly, the player reconstructs Stalvan's history through evidence and firsthand investigation.

Bonus: Going back to a school in Westfall and a town like Goldshire, both places the players has likely been, adds texture to the world and helps enforce that the World as Main Character!

Design Takeaway

A compelling question can make simple objectives feel meaningful.



Design Principle 2: Exploration

Exploration makes the journey part of the reward, and adds depth to the quest

Reveal parts of the world players might otherwise overlook

- Use quests to draw players toward overlooked, hidden, or remote locations

Give players a reason to go there

- Players are more willing to travel when they want to know what's waiting for them

Reward the journey with discovery

- A quest can reveal a cave, ruin, landmark, camp, castle, secret, or vista the player may never have found on their own, becoming a reward in itself

Make the world feel bigger than the quest

- Exploration helps the player feel like an adventurer rather than the main character

Quest Examples that use Exploration really well

**Sleeping Bag
Questline**

Linken's Adventure

Lunaclaw

**Windsor
Onyxia Reveal**

The Missing Diplomat

Case Study: *The Missing Diplomat*

Exploration doesn't always reveal new places; it can also reveal new reasons to care about familiar ones.

How The Missing Diplomat uses Exploration

Reveal parts of the world players might otherwise overlook

Throughout the quest, the player explores places and people in Stormwind, such as a chain of hidden contacts, informants, and locations they would normally run past or never think twice about.

Give players a reason to go there

Each quest step leads the player to another person, location, or piece of evidence almost all placed in locations the player doesn't go to on their own.

Reward the journey with discovery

The quest reveals hidden contacts, overlooked locations, and stories hiding in plain sight! A cheese merchant becomes an informant, familiar districts gain new meaning, and players begin seeing Stormwind in a new way.

Make the world feel bigger than the quest

The Missing Diplomat is only one story, but it reveals criminal networks, political tensions, and relationships that extend far beyond the quest and expand the world's feeling.

Bonus: The Missing Diplomat shows the player nooks and crannies the player would miss, but also leads with curiosity, worldbuilding, and rewards the player with discovery throughout the quest and especially at the end with a very rare NPC cutscene.

Design Takeaway

Exploration is a quest design principle we can use to lean into the World as Main Character and Journey Before Destination pillars, while also keeping the player always looking forward to progressing into the next area.



Design Principle 3: Pacing

Without pacing, every moment feels the same. Meaningful moments need time to develop!

Give players time to become invested

- Relationships, locations, and stories become stronger when players spend time with them
- Emotional moments also become more powerful when they're earned

Escalate the stakes gradually

- Great adventures rarely begin with their biggest moment
- Start small and allow the importance of the story to grow over time

Vary the player's experience

- Changing objectives, locations, and activities helps maintain engagement across longer quest chains

Let important moments breathe

- Travel, preparation, downtime, and reflection make major moments feel more impactful

Quest Examples that demonstrate strong Pacing

Tirion Forging
(emotional payoff)

Onyxia Attunement
(long-term escalation)

The Missing Diplomat
(growing investigation)

The Legend of Stalvan
(gradual mystery reveal)

The Defias Brotherhood
(long recurring local problem)

Case Study: *Tirion Fordring - Redemption*

Each step in this quest chain builds upon itself to gradually tell a story about family, sacrifice, and loss

How The Redemption Questline perfected Pacing

Give the player time to become invested

The player first meets Tirion as an old hermit offering mundane tasks in the form of kill quests. Only after helping him does Tirion reveal he was once one of Lordaeron's greatest paladins.

Escalate the stakes gradually

The story continues to grow and add layers as you progress.

Old Hermit -> Exiled Paladin -> Finding his lost son -> Scarlet Crusade -> Reunion -> Tragedy

Players slowly uncover Tirion's history, his sacrifice, and his hope of reconnecting with Taelan.

Vary the player's experience

The chain constantly changes what the player is doing.

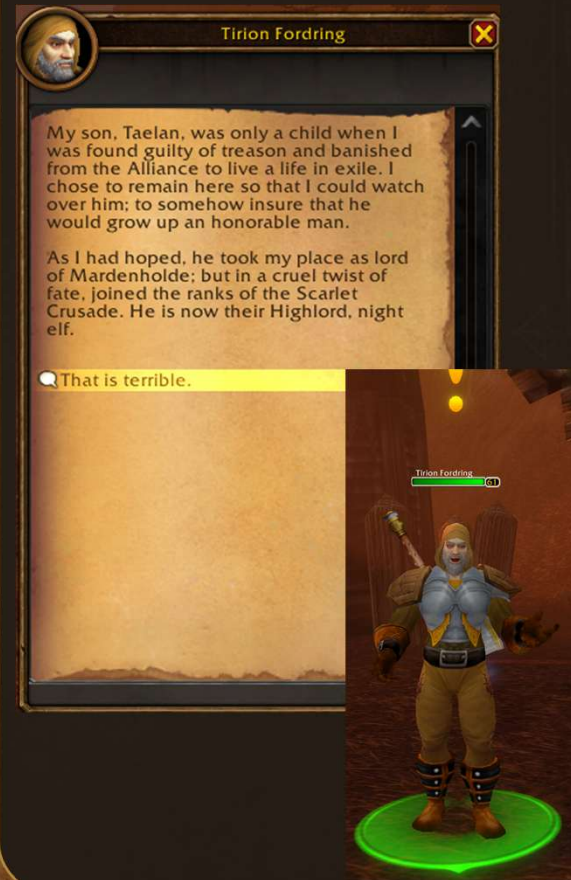
1. Kill plaguehounds and undead
2. Listen to Tirion's story
3. Recover Taelan's Hammer from a forgotten grave
4. Recover the family painting "Of Love and Family"
5. Create a Scarlet Crusade disguise
6. Infiltrate Hearthglen & escort Taelan to freedom

Let important moments breathe

The player spends hours learning about Tirion and Taelan before they ever meet. By the time Taelan decides to leave the Scarlet Crusade, the player already knows Tirion's sacrifice, Taelan's history, and the player wants the reunion to succeed.

Design Takeaway

Meaningful moments are more powerful when players have time to become invested in them. The player remembers Taelan's death because the quest spent hours earning it.



Design Principle 4: Worldbuilding

Allowing the world to be the Main Character by connecting locations together using quest stories

Make the world feel like it has a past

- Revealing events that happened before the player entered the story
- Allow the player to uncover results of the past rather than creating the world themselves

Connect small stories to bigger problems

- Local issues can reveal political, economic, cultural, or social conflicts happening somewhere else in the world
- Smaller stories can feel more meaningful when they're connected to larger stories

Give places a reason to exist

- Linking your locations to greater stories helps make them feel like real places with meaning
- A town, farm, dungeon, or ruins become memorable when players understand what happened there and why

Make the player a part of the world and not the center of it

- Players should feel like an adventurer exploring a living world where events exist beyond player involvement

Quest Examples that demonstrate strong Worldbuilding

**Defias
Brotherhood**

Mankrik's Wife

The Missing Diplomat

The Legend of Stalvan

Onyxia Attunement

Case Study: *Defias Brotherhood*

A local problem with bandits slowly revealed history, politics, and a bigger plot of corruption in Stormwind

How The Defias Brotherhood Builds the World

Make the world feel like it has a past

The player arrives long after the conflict began. The Stonemasons built Stormwind, were denied payment, and were driven from the city, and the player is tasked with helping deal with it.

Connect small stories to bigger problems

At first, the player sees bandits across multiple zones, Elwynn, Westfall, and surrounding Stormwind areas without explanation. It isn't until later that the quests explain who the Defias were and how they're connected to a larger plot.

Give places a reason to exist

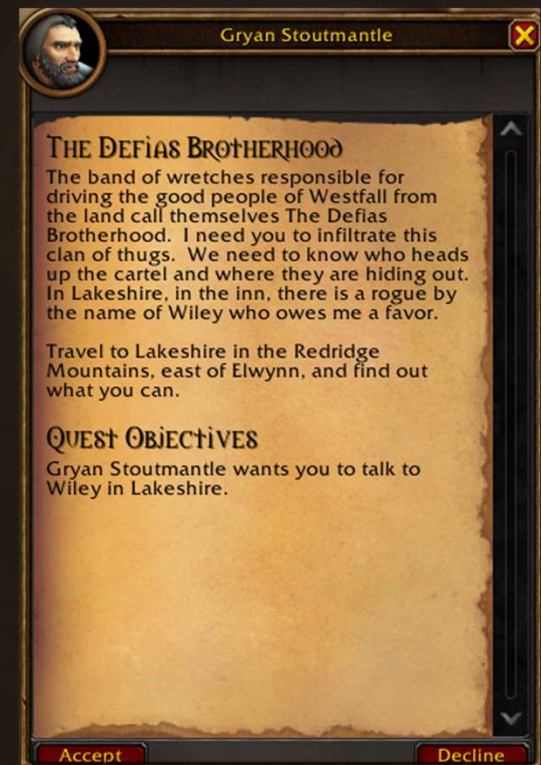
Sentinel Hill becomes a sanctuary from bandits, Moonbrook becomes the remnants of an old community, and the Deadmines becomes the headquarters of a worker's rebellion.

Make the player a part of the world and not the center of it

The Defias Brotherhood is far too big for the player to handle on their own as a simple adventurer. You can impact small stories, farms, and help individuals, but to make big impact you need a group of adventurers to delve into the Deadmines to defeat Edwin VanCleaf.

Design Takeaway

Worldbuilding is strongest when a player quests through stories that shaped the world instead of being simply told about them. Being able to help in small ways paints a larger picture over time and adds meaningful shape to the world.



Design Principle 5: Empathy

Even the strongest heroes still care about the people they love

Give players someone to care about

- Honor and integrity are rooted in Warcraft lore. Our greatest heroes are often the most empathetic, so give our players opportunities to walk in their footsteps.

Ground the story in something personal

- Themes that any one person can relate to in their life (*a husband looking for his wife, a father trying to reconnect with his son, a child waiting for her parents, a soldier trying to honor a fallen friend*)

Use simple themes that are easy to understand

- Family, loss, loyalty, love, duty, and sacrifice are all easy to understand and relate to

Make the player part of the outcome

- A player will both care more and remember the story more when they're a part of the delivery of hope, heartbreak, or impact the outcome in some way.

Quest Examples that demonstrate strong Empathy

Tirion Fording

Mankrik's Wife

Battle of Darrowshire

Little Pamela

For Love Eternal

Case Study: *Mankrik's Wife*

The player begins helping a stranger and ends by witnessing the fall of a family

How Mankrik's Wife Questline exemplifies Empathy

Give players someone to care about

The players meet Mankrik alone in the Barrens, asking anyone he can for help finding his missing wife. He's asking the player to find someone he loves, and the player can immediately understand the problem and gain empathetic motivation.

Ground the story in something personal

The quest presents itself as a personal request to find a worried man's wife. The stakes are personal and that makes it easy to connect with.

Use simple themes that are easy to understand

Family, loss, love, and loyalty are all themes that don't need explanation. Players understand the fear and worry behind a lost loved one and the simplicity in the theme doesn't rely on deep emotional intelligence to hook the player.

Make the player part of the outcome

The adventurer is the one who finds Mankrik's wife slain far from camp, now bound by duty and honor to return the bad news to Mankrik.

Design Takeaway

Players empathize with Mankrik because his problems are relatable, simple, and personal.



Lost in Battle

We battled in a small tauren camp when we were separated--she held three of the Bristlebacks off by herself. But the odds began to overwhelm us. I led some away only to see her overwhelmed by newcomers. In my rage, I turned to face my enemies, but they brought me down easily with their vast numbers.

I awoke to a tauren druid tending my wounds--he had come across me on the Gold Road as I fell.

Please, druid, find some sign of my wife.

QUEST OBJECTIVES

Find Mankrik's wife and then return to him in the Crossroads.



Beaten Corpse

You turn the body over and see the marks from blades and spells upon the deceased orc--her armor all but destroyed, her hair matted to her face.

Based on Mankrik's description of her, there is no doubt in your mind that this was his wife.

He will be upset by the news, but you are sure he should know the truth.

Design Principle 6: *Shared Adventure*

Some of the most memorable and best stories are often the ones players create together

Give players a reason to work together

- Strong elite kill-quests, an important document deep within a castle of dangerous elites, and rewards that are worth grouping up and tackling difficult content to earn.
- We are more likely to make friends when quests create situations where cooperation feels useful and natural.

Encourage cooperation over competition

- When two players run into each other, it should feel like an opportunity to make the experience easier, safer, or more exciting instead of creating friction.
- Many players group inside of caves because of respawn rates, easy to be overwhelmed, and it's nice to have someone watch your back. Making more danger encourages cooperation.

Create challenges that bring players together to overcome

- Elite Quests, dangerous areas, difficult objectives all create shared goals that encourage communication, teamwork, and memorable experiences or lasting friendships.

Quest Examples that bring players together to form Social Stories:

Mor'Ladim

Stromgarde Elites

Jintha'Alor

Pirates in Tanaris

**Redridge Stonewatch
Keep**

Case Study: *Mor'Ladim*

Mor'Ladim was once Morgan Ladimore, a knight who fought alongside Uther in the Second War...it's sad he ended up this way.

How The Mor'Ladim Elite Quest encourages a Shared Adventure

Give players a reason to work together

Mor'Ladim is dangerous, patrols around in an area that is often full of lower leveled quests and players. He hits hard, is surrounded by other threats, and many players naturally seek help rather than attempt killing him alone for that reason.

Encourage cooperation over competition

The more allies you have to help you slay Mor'Ladim the better! He is easier to kill, safer, faster, and all players will receive quest progress, loot, experience, and a chance at making new friends that you can carry with you into a future dungeon or the next Elite Quest.

Create challenges that bring players together to overcome

Mor'Ladim is a strong Elite Quest that requires players to communicate, group up, protect each other, and often remember this quest because it was a shared goal that got the player into a place of preparation, cooperation, and some social interaction to break up the chain of quests in the area.

Bonus: Mor'Ladim was once Morgan Ladimore, a knight who fought alongside Uther in the Second War. When he returned home, he discovered his family was dead and buried in Raven Hill Cemetery. Overcome by grief, he lost his sanity, killed innocent people in his rage, and took his own life, only later rising from the grave as the undead Mor'Ladim. This story leverages Curiosity as to who he is, Empathy for his loss, Worldbuilding with Uther and the War, and Shared Adventure for the challenge.

Design Takeaway

We can encourage community and shared struggle through difficulty in our quests and content. We can't force friendships, but we can create more opportunities for them!



The level 1 Raid on Mor'Ladim in Hardcore WoW's PTR

The Six Pillars of Memorable Quest Design

Curiosity

Gives players a question they want answered

Exploration

Make the journey part of the reward

Pacing

Give important moments time to matter

Worldbuilding

Make the world feel larger than the player

Empathy

Give players people they care about

Shared Adventure

Create opportunities for players to work together

The most memorable quests often have multiple principles practiced within one quest chain!

Curiosity

A question the player wants answered

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Scarcity is KEY!!

Too much of one thing is almost always BAD!

“And when everyone’s super...no one will be!” -

A typical Zone might have 30-100 quests:

- We have evidence that there are generally 1-2 that are memorable with extreme depth



Be very intentional about adding these styles of quests, and when you do, leverage these design principles!

<u>Zone</u>	<u>Approx. quest entries</u>	<u>Memorable questlines I'd count</u>	<u>Rough ratio</u>
Westfall	35	Defias Brotherhood, maybe Captain Sander	~1-2 / 35
Elwynn Forest	36-49 depending source	Hogger, Kobolds, Goldtooth/Princess	~1-2 / 36-49
Duskwood	76-79	Stalvan, Mor'Ladim, maybe Bride of the Embalmer	~2-3 / 76-79
Redridge Mountains	36	Stonewatch / Blackrock elites, maybe Missing in Action	~1-2 / 36
Silverpine Forest	42	Arugal's Folly, Pyrewood/Fenris	~1-2 / 42
Hillsbrad Foothills	53	Battle of Hillsbrad, Helcular, Taretha/Blackmoore	~2-3 / 53
The Barrens	98-104	Mankrik, Barrens Oases/Wailing Caverns, Echeyakee, Chen's Keg	~2-4 / 98-104
Stranglethorn Vale	113-150 depending source	Green Hills, Nesingwary mastery, Kurzen, Bloodsail, Cortello	~4-6 / 113-150
Eastern Plaguelands	108-109	Tirion/Redemption, Pamela/Darrowshire, Nathanos	~2-3 / 108-109
Tanaris	94-101	Noggenfogger, Tooga, OOX, Zul'Farrak/Gahz'rilla	~3-5 / 94-101
Thousand Needles	63	Test of Faith, Arikara, Mirage Raceway/Salt Flats	~2-3 / 63

What fills the space between big moments?

Not every quest needs to be memorable, and this is our chance to have inconsistency

World Reinforcement

- Hunting dangerous wildlife
- Delivering supplies between settlements
- Helping farmers and townfolk
- Solving local problems
- Learning about factions and cultures
- Experience daily life in the world

Examples:

- Westfall Stew
- Redridge Goulash
- Chen's Empty Keg
- The Night Watch
- Rebel Camp Quests

Variety Creates Adventure

Not knowing what comes next is part of what makes Classic exciting! The inconsistency is a feature and not a flaw. Feel free to be creative with your quest and make different experiences.

Examples:

- Kill Creatures
- Escort an NPC
- Search for Clues
- Explore a cave
- Fight an elite
- Deliver a message
- Read a journal
- Gather ingredients

An adventurer remembers the big moments because they are surrounded by everyday adventures

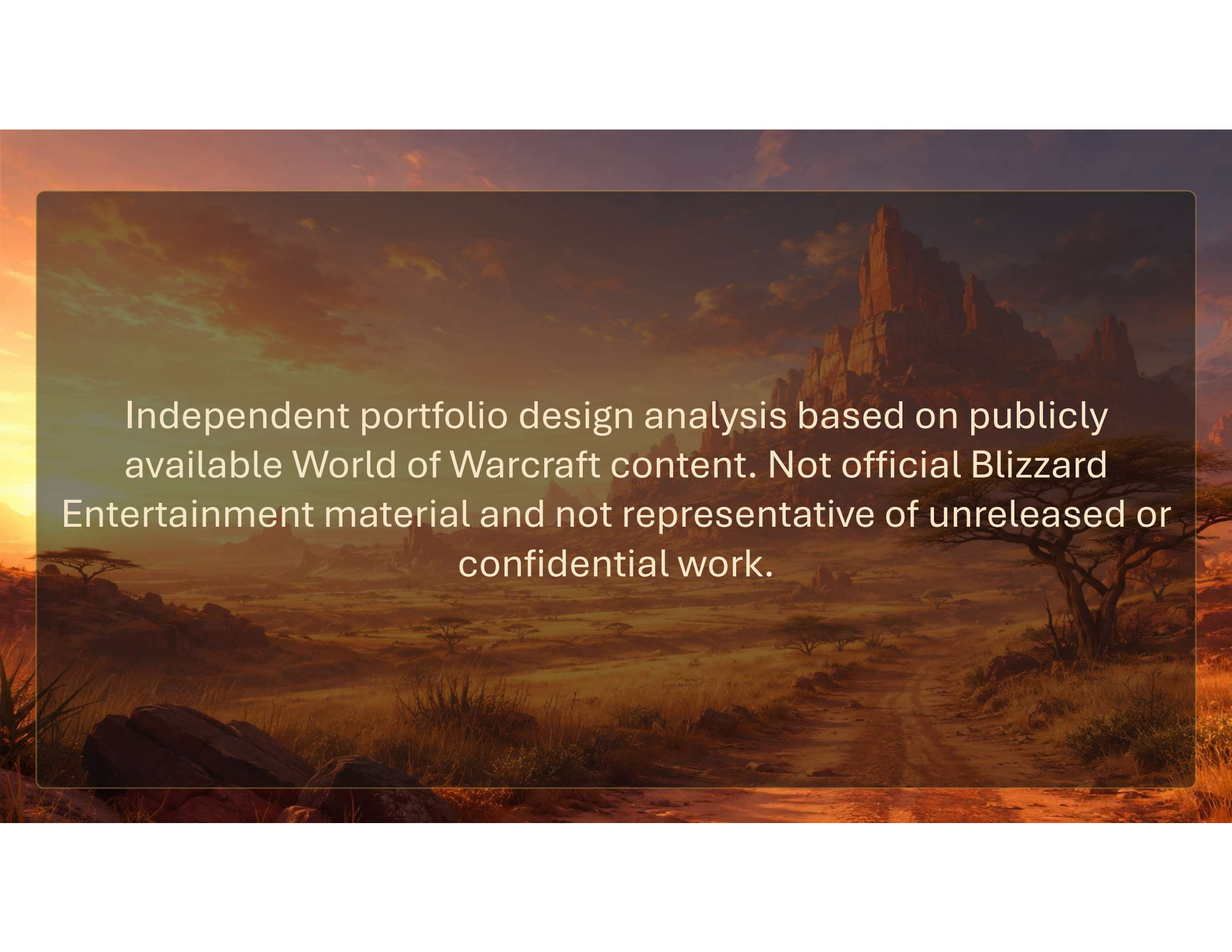
Design Takeaways

What will you go create next?

We all are adventurers on our own journey

Every journey is different, and that's what makes it meaningful. There is no perfect formula for creating the best quest, the same way there isn't a formula for living the best life. The world, people, mysteries, and adventures we create are what give shape to the journey. So build worlds worth exploring, stories worth sharing, and most importantly have fun creating them!

For the love of our game ♥



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